well as other world leaders, that the US was serious about the prisoner issue.[194] So the prime minister had urged Zhou to meet with Hammarskjold.[195] After meeting Eisenhower and Dulles, even Krishna Menon came to understand the resonance of the issue in Washington and recommended that Delhi suggest to Beijing that it release at least some prisoners as a goodwill gesture.[196] And Nehru subsequently raised the issue with Zhou in Bandung.[197]

US officials remained unconvinced about India as intermediary, but Delhi nonetheless played a role. After Bandung, India announced that Krishna Menon would visit Beijing to discuss the prisoner issue. US officials were keen to ensure he knew that he did not have a "mandate" to speak for the US.[198] China did agree to release four detained airmen after Krishna Menon's visit, which Nehru took credit for.[199] The Indian envoy told John Sherman Cooper, former senator and new ambassador to India, that Beijing did not release all the airmen because of public opinion and the desire to assess the response to that first step.[200] Thus, when Krishna Menon subsequently met Dulles and Eisenhower, he urged them to take steps to reassure China.

Dulles, however, pointed out that the US had already taken such steps. Even during the Korean War the US had ceased fire first, despite some domestic opposition. Furthermore, since then, the US had facilitated the Taiwanese withdrawal from one of the offshore islands, ensured that the MDT did not cover the offshore islands, and restrained Taiwan from attacking airbases on the mainland. Washington was also considering changing operating instructions for US aircraft so that their flights were less provocative, and trying to make repatriation for Chinese students easier. Dulles stressed that a war with China was not desirable. He recognized that it would not remain limited, with the possibility of Soviet involvement and the use of nuclear weapons—and even if the US emerged victorious, it would be left holding the bag in China.

Krishna Menon thought, however, that the US could do more, by allowing US citizens to visit China, urging Taiwan not to follow a "scorched-earth" policy on the offshore islands, and not setting preconditions for negotiations. Dulles, on his part, did not want to negotiate prematurely even though he had detected a change in Chinese attitude. China was using American prisoners as bargaining tools and expected to be